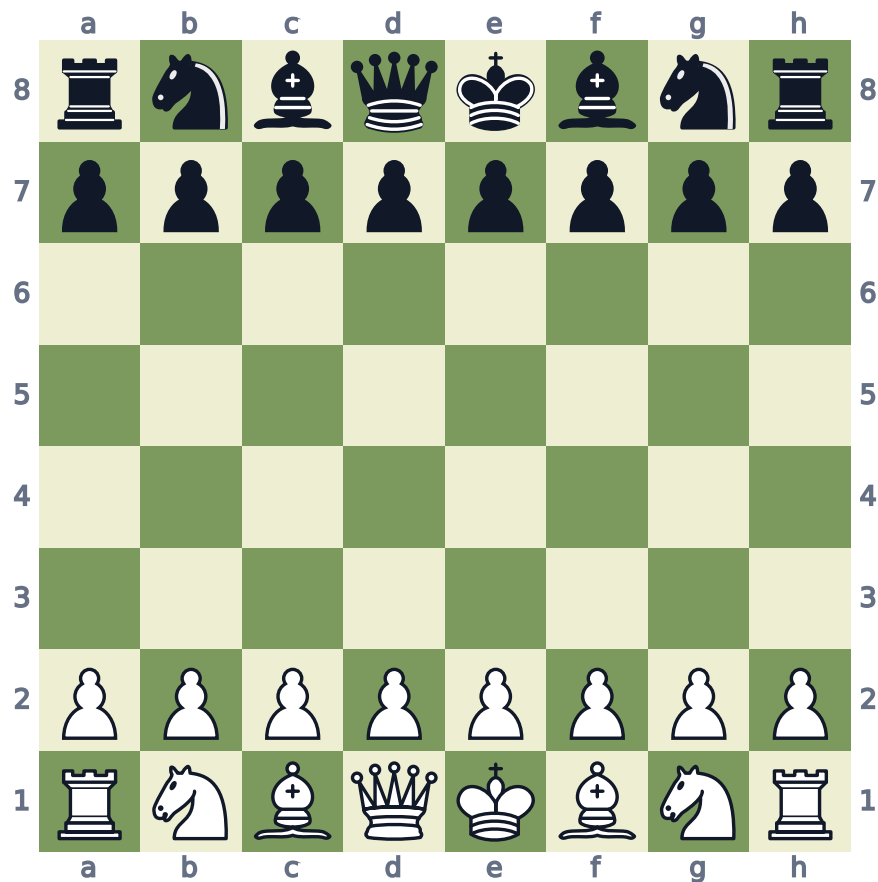


Piece-by-Piece Mastery

Ideal squares, routes, limitations, and cooperation



Understand each unit as a problem-solving tool: what it needs from the pawn structure, what limits it, and how it coordinates with the rest of the army.

24 learning units | explanations | board laboratories | review system

ORIENTATION

What this course will change

COURSE PROMISE

Understand each unit as a problem-solving tool: what it needs from the pawn structure, what limits it, and how it coordinates with the rest of the army.

YOU WILL LEARN TO

- Place knights and bishops according to structure
- Activate rooks and use entry squares
- Coordinate the queen without exposing it
- Use the king as both a liability and a fighting piece
-

HOW TO USE THE COURSE

- Study one learning unit at a time. Say the rule in your own words before continuing.
- At each diagram, hide the model answer. Write candidates and the opponent's best reply.
- Use the rule during a slow game, then record whether it actually changed a decision.
- Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days. Retrieval matters more than rereading.
-

SCOPE

This course contains 24 integrated learning units. Principles guide attention, but tactics and exact calculation always decide the move.

CORE METHOD

The decision protocol

USE THIS EVERY TIME

A reliable process is more valuable than a brilliant idea used occasionally. Practice the sequence until it becomes automatic under clock pressure.

1**Check tactics first.****2****Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.****3****Name the most important imbalance.****4****Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.****5****Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.****STOPPING RULE**

Choose when one candidate is sufficiently verified for the clock situation. Before moving, inspect the position once from the opponent's perspective.

COURSE MAP

Learning units

- 01 Treat Pawn Moves as Permanent Commitments
- 02 Use Pawn Breaks to Change the Position
- 03 Create and Support Passed Pawns
- 04 Centralize Knights on Stable Squares
- 05 Plan Knight Routes Several Moves Ahead
- 06 Use Knights in Closed Positions
- 07 Open the Bishop's Diagonal
- 08 Judge Good and Bad Bishops by Function
- 09 Use the Bishop Pair in Open Positions
- 10 Occupy Files With an Entry Square
- 11 Use the Seventh Rank Actively
- 12 Place Rooks Behind Passed Pawns
- 13 Coordinate the Queen With Smaller Pieces
- 14 Centralize the Queen Only When Safe
- 15 Use Queen Checks With an Exit Plan
- 16 Make King Safety a Concrete Evaluation
- 17 Activate the King as Material Disappears
- 18 Use Opposition and Zugzwang
- 19 Make Every Piece Participate
- 20 Use Batteries and Alignment

COURSE MAP

Learning units

- 21 Avoid Pieces Competing for One Square
- 22 Exchange the Piece the Opponent Needs
- 23 Coordinate Before Accelerating
- 24 Compare Pieces by Future Potential

LEARNING UNIT 01

Treat Pawn Moves as Permanent Commitments

THE RULE

Move a pawn only after naming the squares, lines, and future breaks that the move changes.

WHY IT WORKS

Pawns cannot retreat, so every advance gains something and abandons something. Their fixed geometry becomes the map for every other piece.

RECOGNITION CUES

The pawns determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

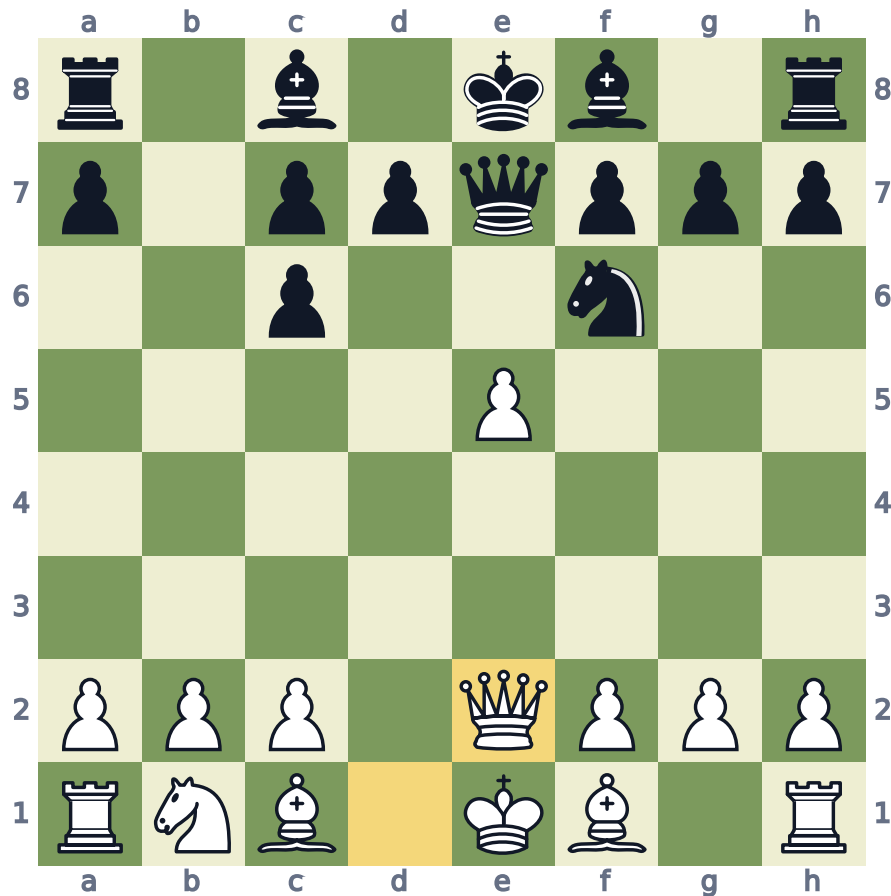
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 01

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



4... Nf6 5. Nxc6 bxc6 6. e5 Qe7 7. Qe2

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Treat Pawn Moves as Permanent Commitments'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Pawns cannot retreat, so every advance gains something and abandons something. Their fixed geometry becomes the map for every other piece. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring treat pawn moves as permanent commitments. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 02

Use Pawn Breaks to Change the Position

THE RULE

Prepare a pawn contact that opens the file or diagonal your pieces are ready to use.

WHY IT WORKS

A pawn break is the main way to transform a closed or stable structure. Preparation matters because the resulting lines reward the better placed army.

RECOGNITION CUES

The pawns determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

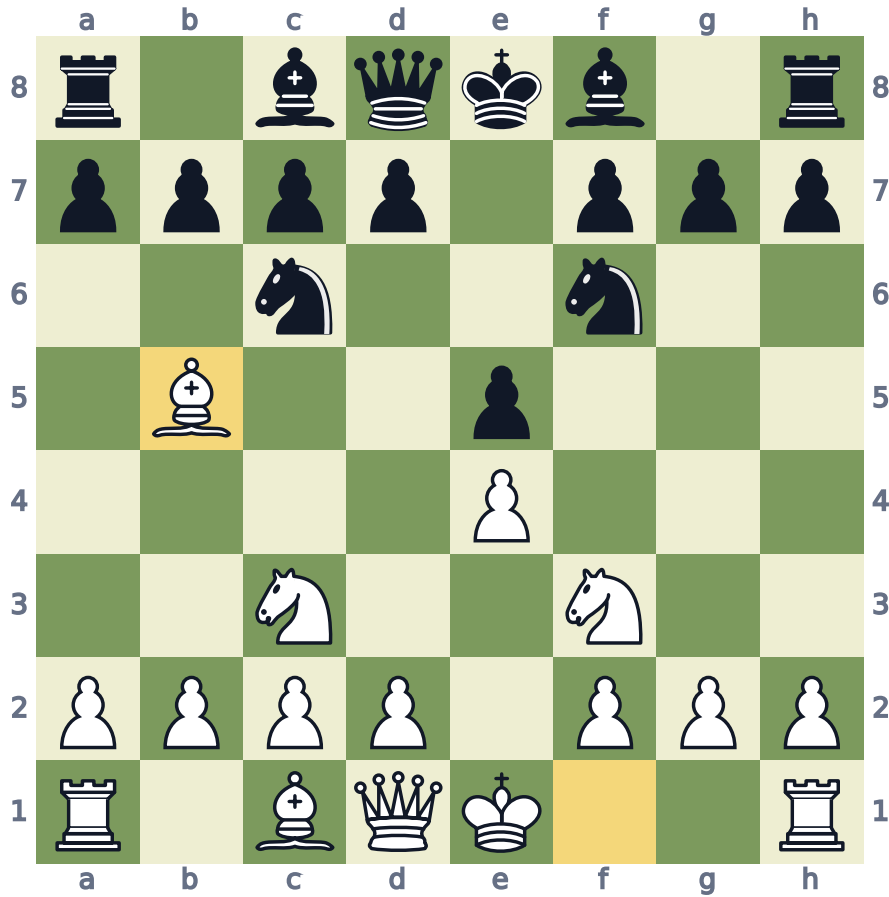
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 02

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



1... e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bb5

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Use Pawn Breaks to Change the Position'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A pawn break is the main way to transform a closed or stable structure. Preparation matters because the resulting lines reward the better placed army. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring use pawn breaks to change the position. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 03

Create and Support Passed Pawns

THE RULE

Create a passed pawn only with a plan for blockade, escort, and promotion timing.

WHY IT WORKS

A passed pawn restricts enemy pieces and gains value as material disappears, but an overextended passer can become a target.

RECOGNITION CUES

The pawns determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

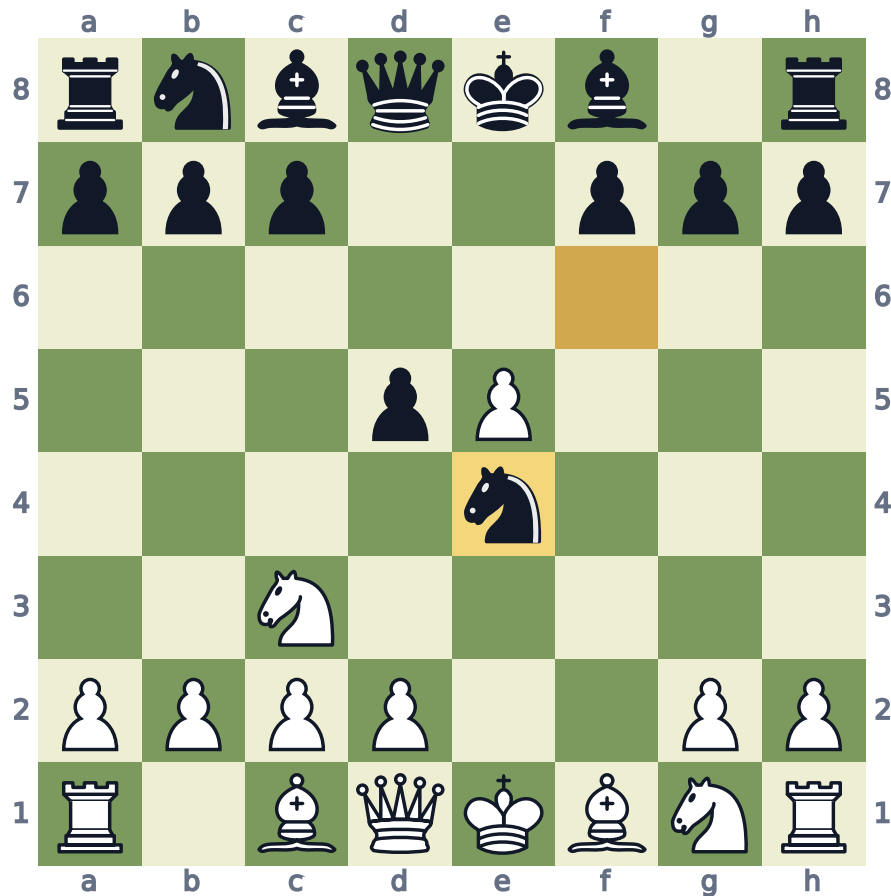
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 03

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



2. Nc3 Nf6 3. f4 d5 4. fxe5 Nxe4

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Create and Support Passed Pawns'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A passed pawn restricts enemy pieces and gains value as material disappears, but an overextended passer can become a target. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring create and support passed pawns. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 04

Centralize Knights on Stable Squares

THE RULE

Seek protected central outposts that enemy pawns cannot challenge.

WHY IT WORKS

A knight's short range makes square quality decisive. A stable central knight influences both wings and can dominate higher-value pieces.

RECOGNITION CUES

The knights determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 04

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



4. h4 g4 5. Ne5 Nf6 6. Bc4 d5

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Centralize Knights on Stable Squares'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A knight's short range makes square quality decisive. A stable central knight influences both wings and can dominate higher-value pieces. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring centralize knights on stable squares. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 05

Plan Knight Routes Several Moves Ahead

THE RULE

Name the destination square first, then calculate the safest route and whether it arrives in time.

WHY IT WORKS

Knights often require two or three moves to improve. A route is justified when the position stays closed enough and the destination changes the struggle.

RECOGNITION CUES

The knights determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

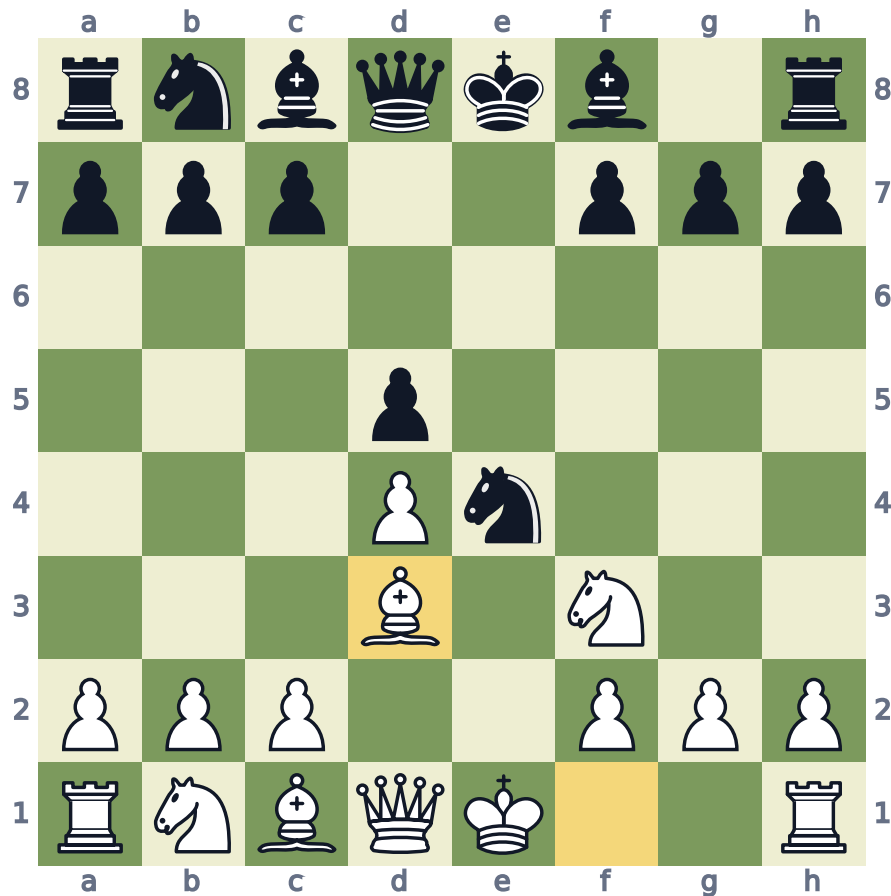
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 05

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



3... d6 4. Nf3 Nxe4 5. d4 d5 6. Bd3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Plan Knight Routes Several Moves Ahead'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Knights often require two or three moves to improve. A route is justified when the position stays closed enough and the destination changes the struggle. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring plan knight routes several moves ahead. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 06

Use Knights in Closed Positions

THE RULE

Favor knights when fixed pawns block long diagonals and stable outposts exist.

WHY IT WORKS

Knights jump over congestion and can attack fixed weaknesses without needing open lines. Their relative value rises when bishops lack scope.

RECOGNITION CUES

The knights determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

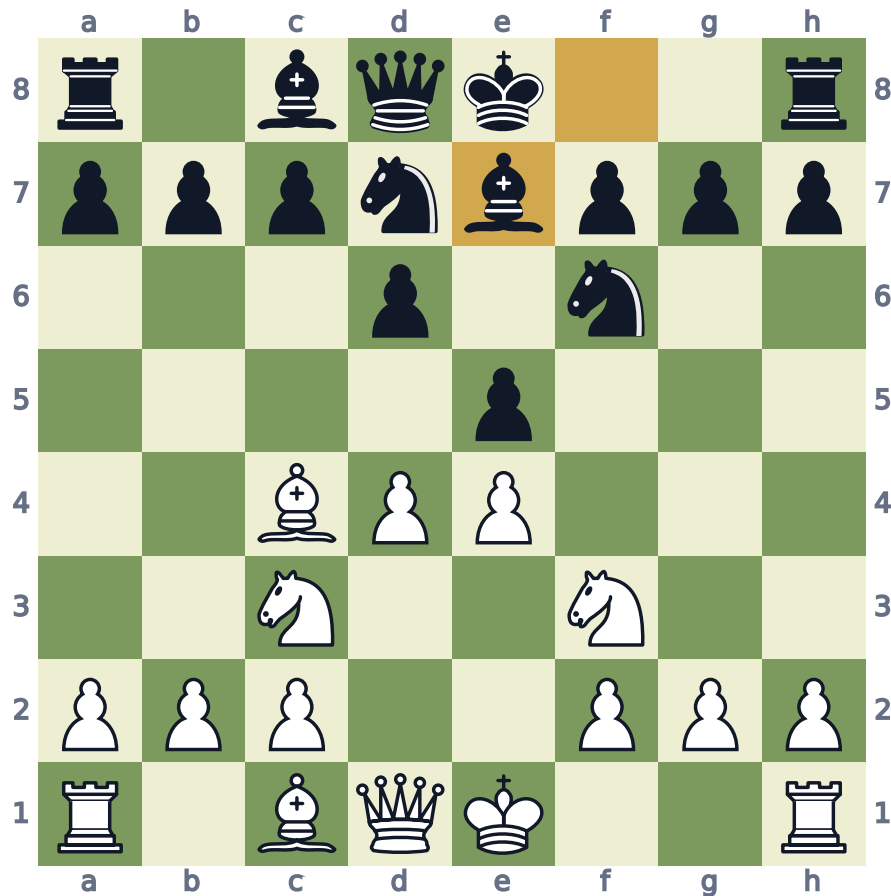
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 06

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



3. d4 Nf6 4. Nc3 Nbd7 5. Bc4 Be7

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Use Knights in Closed Positions'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Knights jump over congestion and can attack fixed weaknesses without needing open lines. Their relative value rises when bishops lack scope. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring use knights in closed positions. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 07

Open the Bishop's Diagonal

THE RULE

Use pawn exchanges and placement outside the chain to give the bishop meaningful targets.

WHY IT WORKS

A bishop's theoretical range has no value when its own pawns block it. One structural change can activate it across the entire board.

RECOGNITION CUES

The bishops determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

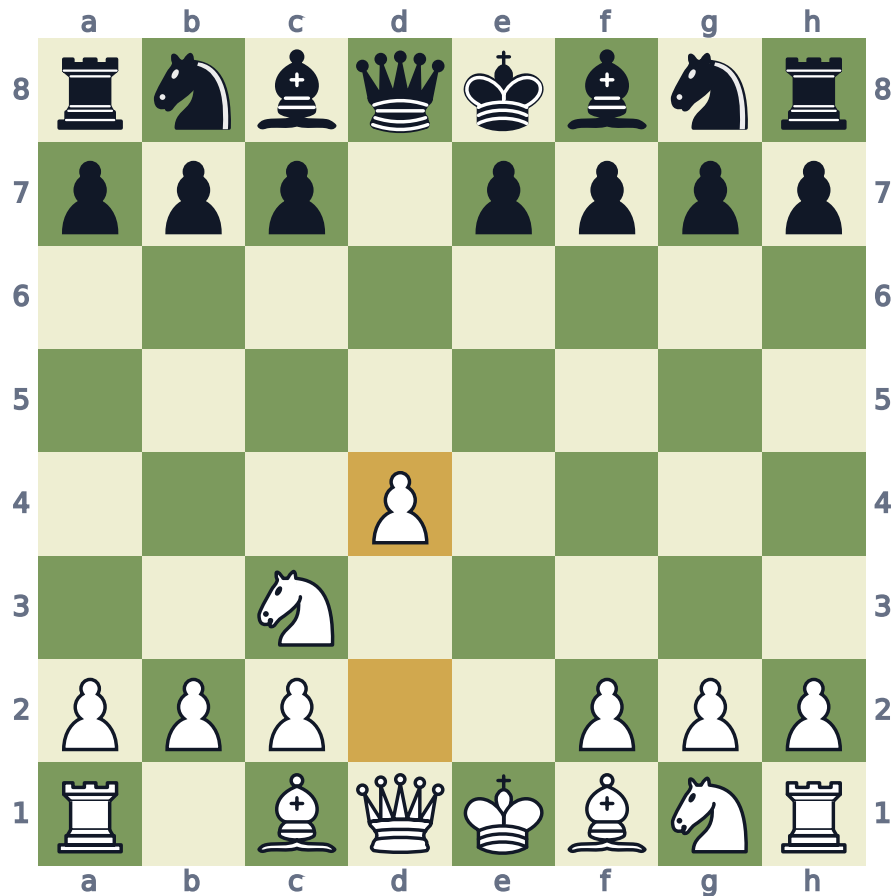
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 07

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



1... d5 2. exd5 Qxd5 3. Nc3 Qd8 4. d4

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Open the Bishop's Diagonal'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A bishop's theoretical range has no value when its own pawns block it. One structural change can activate it across the entire board. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring open the bishop's diagonal. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 08

Judge Good and Bad Bishops by Function

THE RULE

Do not label a bishop bad only because pawns share its color; ask whether it defends, attacks, or can escape the chain.

WHY IT WORKS

A restricted bishop may perform essential defensive work, while a visually good bishop may attack nothing. Function is more important than the label.

RECOGNITION CUES

The bishops determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 08

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



1... e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. e5

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Judge Good and Bad Bishops by Function'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A restricted bishop may perform essential defensive work, while a visually good bishop may attack nothing. Function is more important than the label. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring judge good and bad bishops by function. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 09

Use the Bishop Pair in Open Positions

THE RULE

Preserve two bishops when the center is likely to open and targets exist on both colors.

WHY IT WORKS

Two bishops coordinate across both color complexes and can switch wings quickly. Their advantage grows as pawns are exchanged and lines lengthen.

RECOGNITION CUES

The bishops determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 09

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



3. e5 Bf5 4. Nf3 e6 5. Be2 c5

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Use the Bishop Pair in Open Positions'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Two bishops coordinate across both color complexes and can switch wings quickly. Their advantage grows as pawns are exchanged and lines lengthen. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring use the bishop pair in open positions. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 10

Occupy Files With an Entry Square

THE RULE

A rook belongs on an open or half-open file only when it can penetrate, attack a target, or support a break.

WHY IT WORKS

File ownership is useful through access. Without an entry square or target, a rook may look active while accomplishing nothing.

RECOGNITION CUES

The rooks determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

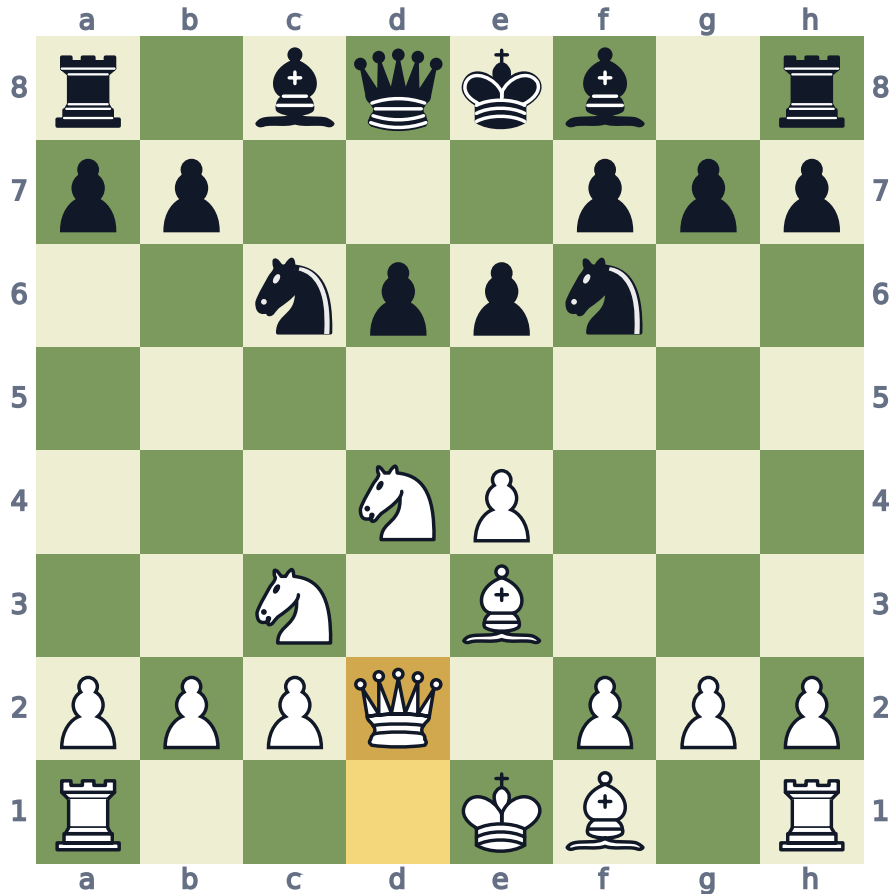
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 10

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



4... Nf6 5. Nc3 Nc6 6. Be3 e6 7. Qd2

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Occupy Files With an Entry Square'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: File ownership is useful through access. Without an entry square or target, a rook may look active while accomplishing nothing. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring occupy files with an entry square. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 11

Use the Seventh Rank Actively

THE RULE

Penetrate to the seventh rank when pawns and king can be attacked without trapping the rook.

WHY IT WORKS

A seventh-rank rook attacks pawns from the side, restricts the king, and often creates mating threats. Safety and retreat squares still matter.

RECOGNITION CUES

The rooks determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 11

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



1... c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Use the Seventh Rank Actively'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A seventh-rank rook attacks pawns from the side, restricts the king, and often creates mating threats. Safety and retreat squares still matter. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring use the seventh rank actively. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 12

Place Rooks Behind Passed Pawns

THE RULE

Put the rook behind a passed pawn, whether supporting your own or restraining the opponent's, when geometry permits.

WHY IT WORKS

From behind, the rook gains range as the pawn advances. Side checks and tactical exceptions must still be calculated.

RECOGNITION CUES

The rooks determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 12

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 g6

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Place Rooks Behind Passed Pawns'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: From behind, the rook gains range as the pawn advances. Side checks and tactical exceptions must still be calculated. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring place rooks behind passed pawns. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 13

Coordinate the Queen With Smaller Pieces

THE RULE

Use the queen to multiply existing pressure rather than attack alone.

WHY IT WORKS

The queen is powerful but vulnerable to tempo attacks. Coordination with bishops, knights, and rooks creates threats that cannot be answered by chasing one piece.

RECOGNITION CUES

The queens determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

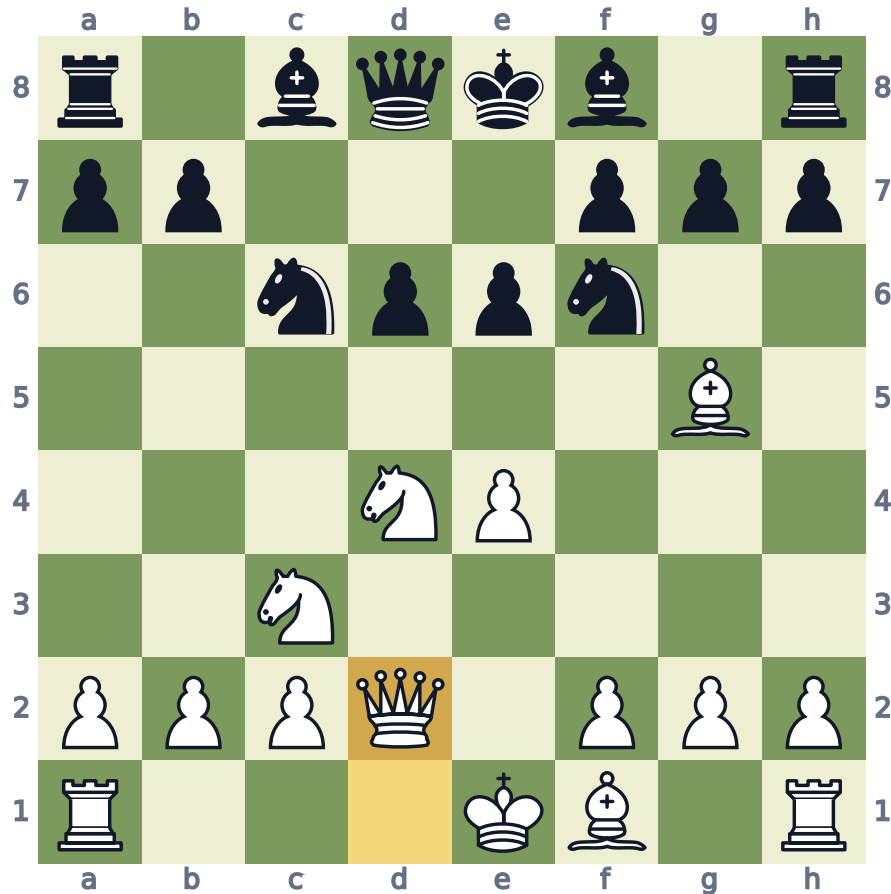
- Check tactics first.
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- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 13

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



4... Nf6 5. Nc3 Nc6 6. Bg5 e6 7. Qd2

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Coordinate the Queen With Smaller Pieces'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: The queen is powerful but vulnerable to tempo attacks. Coordination with bishops, knights, and rooks creates threats that cannot be answered by chasing one piece. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring coordinate the queen with smaller pieces. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 14

Centralize the Queen Only When Safe

THE RULE

Place the queen centrally when enemy pieces cannot gain development by attacking it.

WHY IT WORKS

A central queen controls many lines, but its value makes attacks forcing. Safety and the opponent's tempo gains determine whether centralization helps.

RECOGNITION CUES

The queens determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

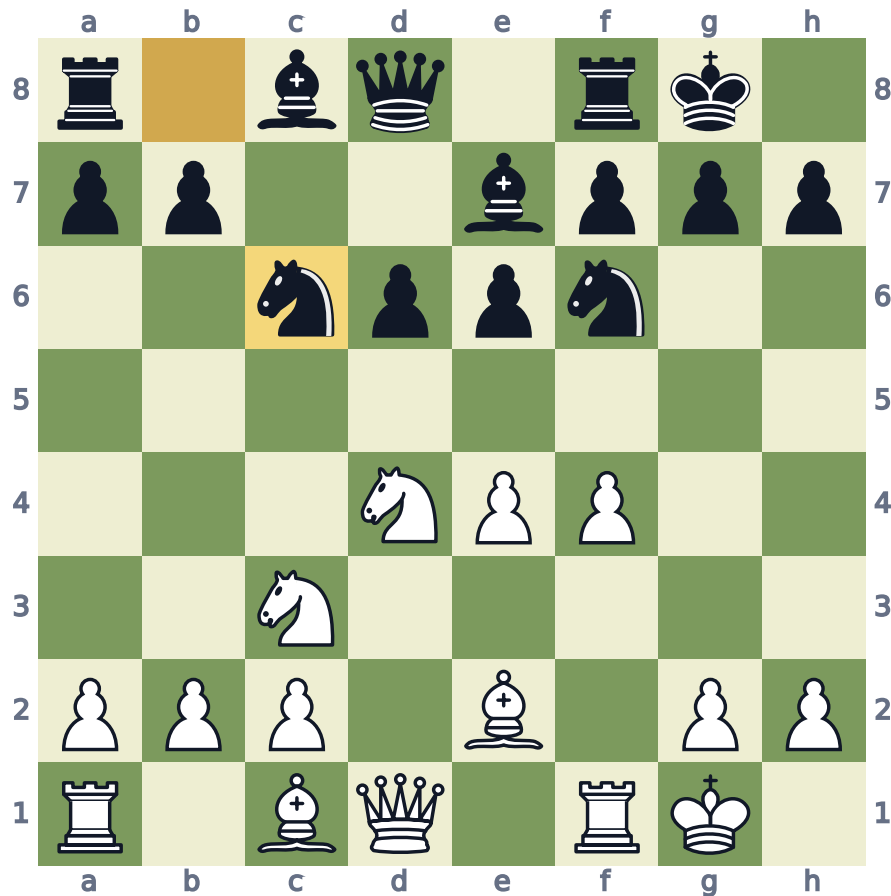
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 14

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



6. Be2 Be7 7. O-O O-O 8. f4 Nc6

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Centralize the Queen Only When Safe'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A central queen controls many lines, but its value makes attacks forcing. Safety and the opponent's tempo gains determine whether centralization helps. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring centralize the queen only when safe. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 15

Use Queen Checks With an Exit Plan

THE RULE

Before checking, calculate where the queen will stand after the king's best reply and whether it can be trapped.

WHY IT WORKS

Checks feel forcing, but a useless check may improve the enemy king and misplace the queen. The destination position decides the check's value.

RECOGNITION CUES

The queens determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 15

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



5... Bg7 6. Be3 Nf6 7. Bc4 O-O 8. Bb3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Use Queen Checks With an Exit Plan'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Checks feel forcing, but a useless check may improve the enemy king and misplace the queen. The destination position decides the check's value. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring use queen checks with an exit plan. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 16

Make King Safety a Concrete Evaluation

THE RULE

Judge safety by open lines, attackers, defenders, escape squares, and queen presence.

WHY IT WORKS

A pawn shield can look intact while lines are accessible, and an exposed king can be safe after queens leave. Safety changes with every exchange.

RECOGNITION CUES

The kings determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 16

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nc6

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Make King Safety a Concrete Evaluation'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A pawn shield can look intact while lines are accessible, and an exposed king can be safe after queens leave. Safety changes with every exchange. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring make king safety a concrete evaluation. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 17

Activate the King as Material Disappears

THE RULE

Centralize the king once checks and mating threats no longer dominate.

WHY IT WORKS

The king becomes a strong short-range piece in endings. Early activation saves tempi and supports pawns, but the transition must be timed precisely.

RECOGNITION CUES

The kings determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

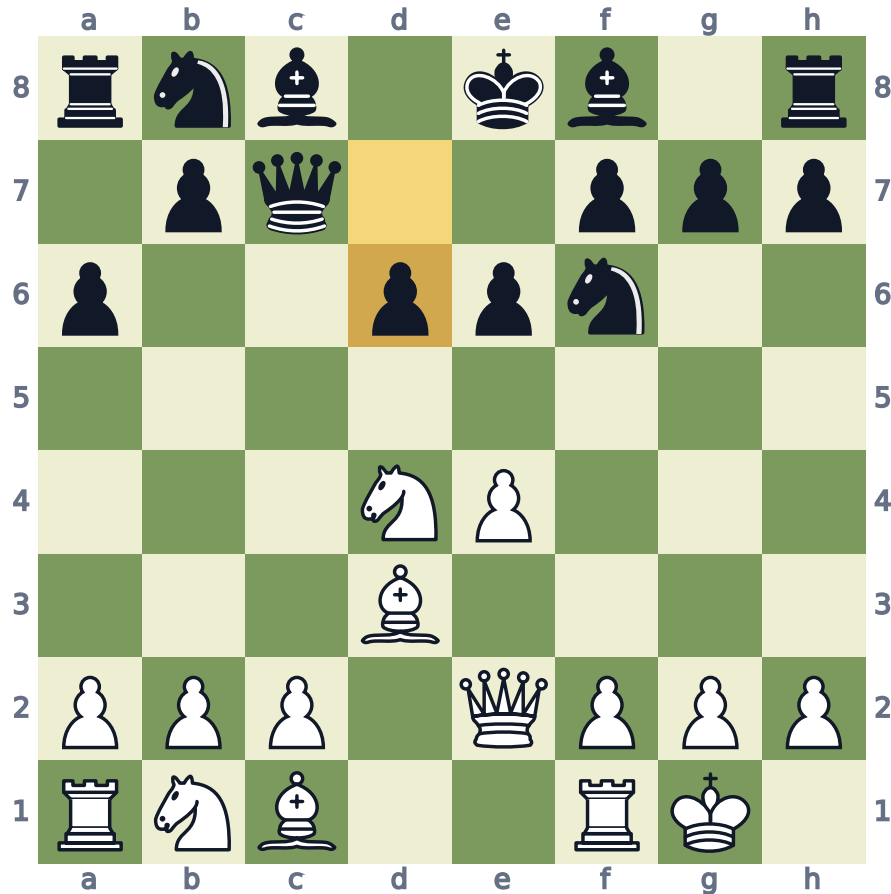
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 17

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



5. Bd3 Qc7 6. O-O Nf6 7. Qe2 d6

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Activate the King as Material Disappears'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: The king becomes a strong short-range piece in endings. Early activation saves tempi and supports pawns, but the transition must be timed precisely. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring activate the king as material disappears. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 18

Use Opposition and Zugzwang

THE RULE

Control the critical entry squares by arranging whose king must move first.

WHY IT WORKS

With few pieces, a single tempo changes access. Opposition is a geometric method for forcing the enemy king to yield ground.

RECOGNITION CUES

The kings determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

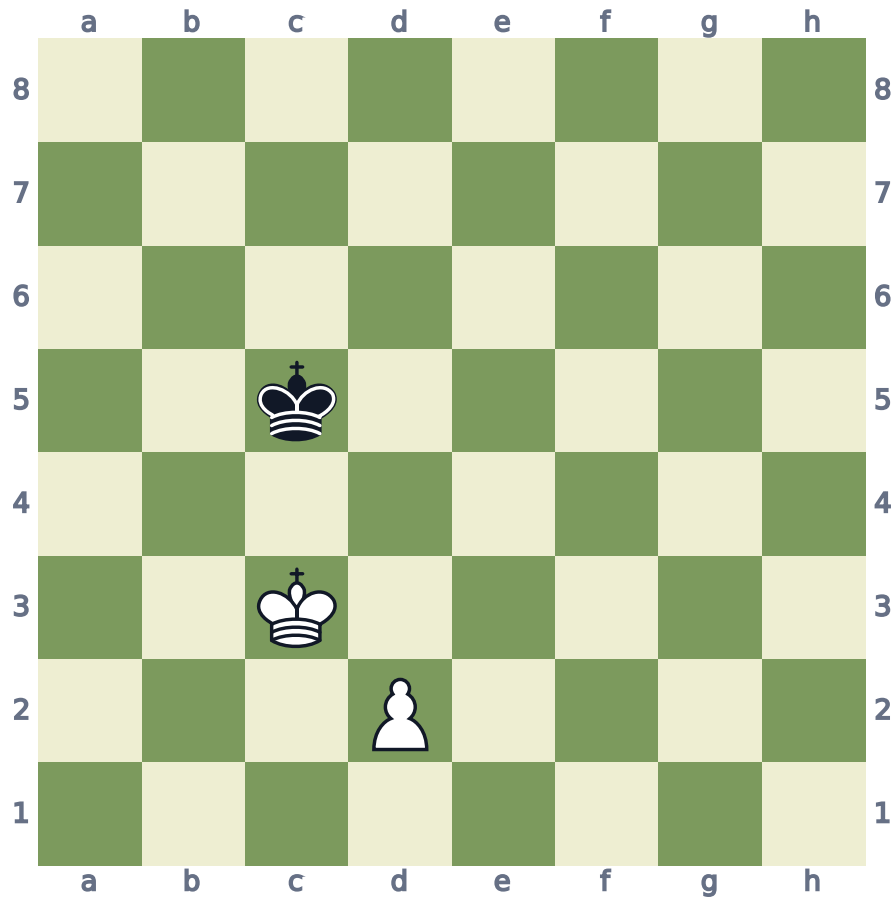
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 18

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



Exact endgame laboratory

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Use Opposition and Zugzwang'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: With few pieces, a single tempo changes access. Opposition is a geometric method for forcing the enemy king to yield ground. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring use opposition and zugzwang. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 19

Make Every Piece Participate

THE RULE

Before beginning an operation, identify the least involved piece and its fastest useful route.

WHY IT WORKS

Attacks and defenses succeed through local numerical superiority. An idle piece is material that does not currently exist in the critical sector.

RECOGNITION CUES

The coordination determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

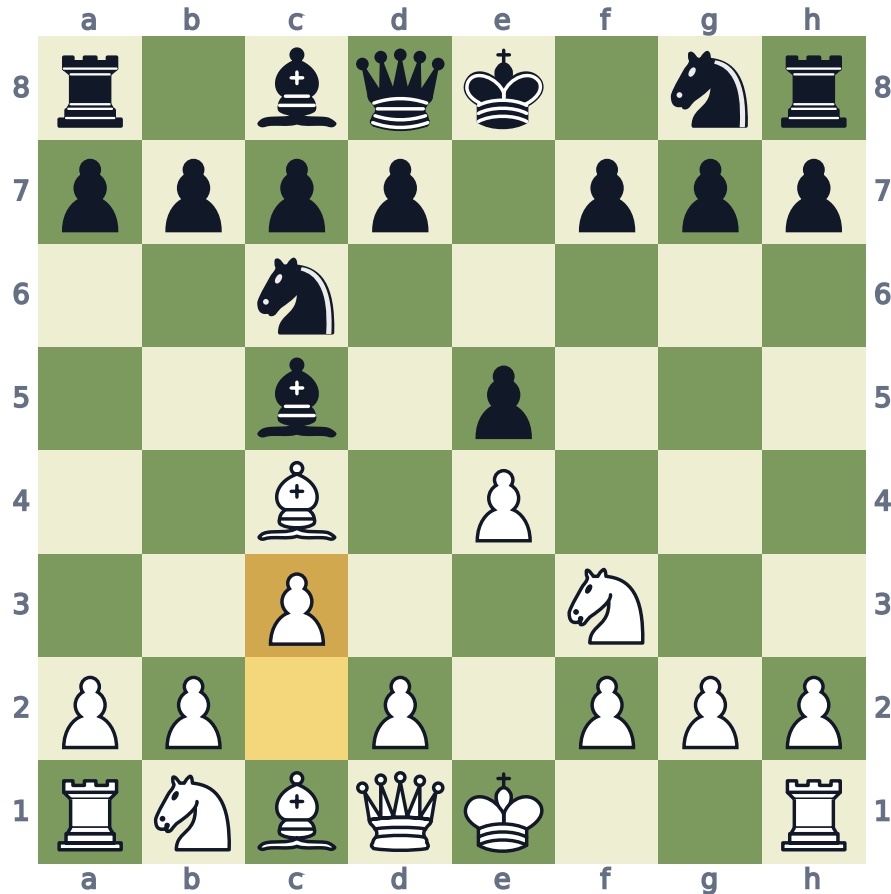
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 19

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



1... e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. c3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Make Every Piece Participate'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Attacks and defenses succeed through local numerical superiority. An idle piece is material that does not currently exist in the critical sector. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring make every piece participate. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 20

Use Batteries and Alignment

THE RULE

Place long-range pieces on a shared line only when the line can be opened or a target already exists.

WHY IT WORKS

A battery concentrates force and creates tactical possibilities, but it is useful only when geometry connects it to an actual target.

RECOGNITION CUES

The coordination determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

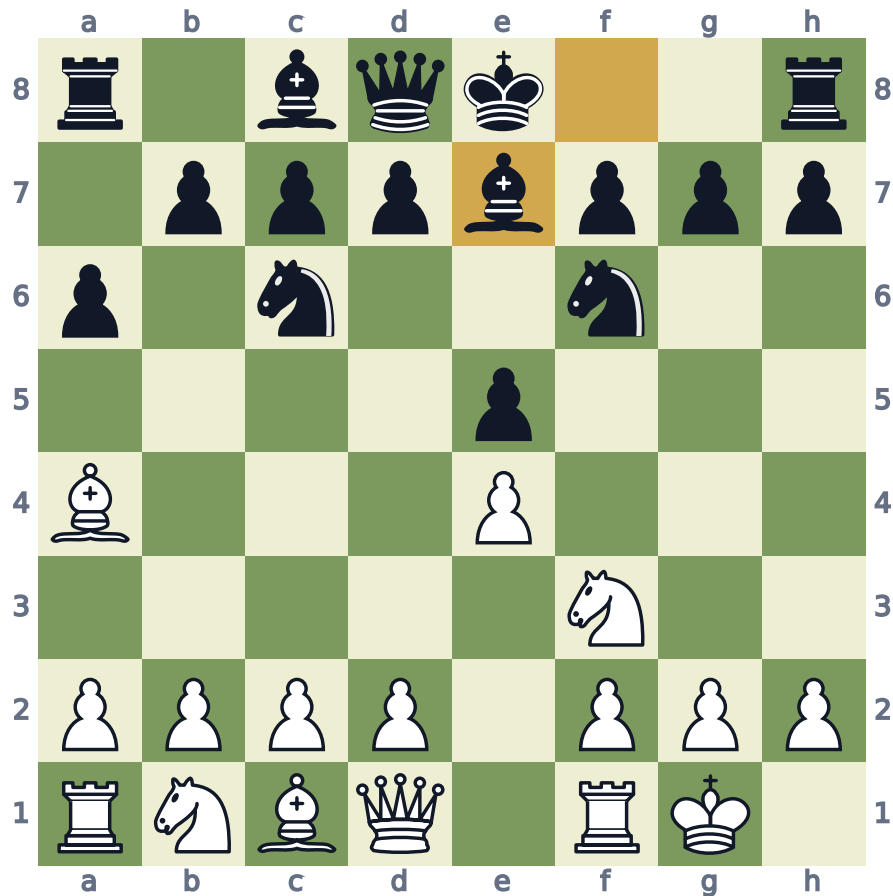
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 20

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Use Batteries and Alignment'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A battery concentrates force and creates tactical possibilities, but it is useful only when geometry connects it to an actual target. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring use batteries and alignment. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 21

Avoid Pieces Competing for One Square

THE RULE

Choose routes that improve several pieces instead of blocking one another.

WHY IT WORKS

Coordination is partly the management of limited squares. A beautiful outpost is not useful if occupying it traps another unit or blocks a file.

RECOGNITION CUES

The coordination determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

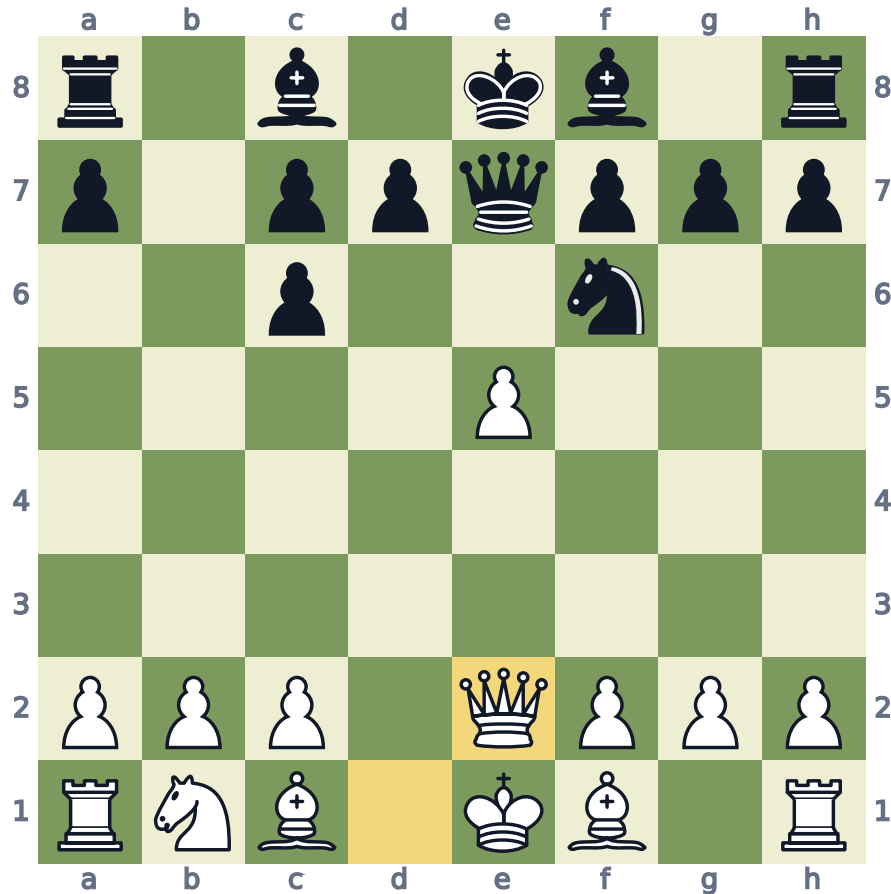
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 21

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



4... Nf6 5. Nxc6 bxc6 6. e5 Qe7 7. Qe2

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Avoid Pieces Competing for One Square'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Coordination is partly the management of limited squares. A beautiful outpost is not useful if occupying it traps another unit or blocks a file. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring avoid pieces competing for one square. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 22

Exchange the Piece the Opponent Needs

THE RULE

Identify the opponent's key attacker, defender, or blockader and calculate a favorable exchange.

WHY IT WORKS

Piece value is contextual. Removing the unit that makes the opponent's plan work can be worth more than preserving a nominally superior piece.

RECOGNITION CUES

The coordination determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

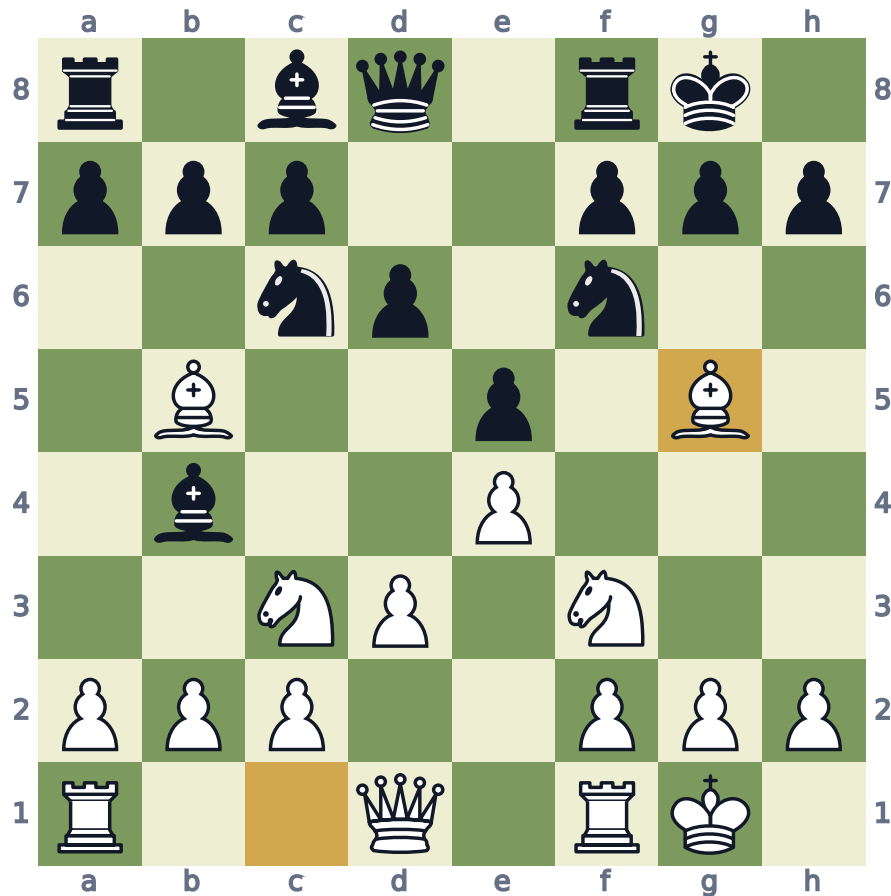
- Check tactics first.
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- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 22

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



4... Bb4 5. O-O O-O 6. d3 d6 7. Bg5

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Exchange the Piece the Opponent Needs'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Piece value is contextual. Removing the unit that makes the opponent's plan work can be worth more than preserving a nominally superior piece. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring exchange the piece the opponent needs. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 23

Coordinate Before Accelerating

THE RULE

Complete development and connect the army before launching irreversible operations.

WHY IT WORKS

A coordinated force can switch from attack to defense and exploit opened lines. Premature action creates targets faster than support can arrive.

RECOGNITION CUES

The coordination determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

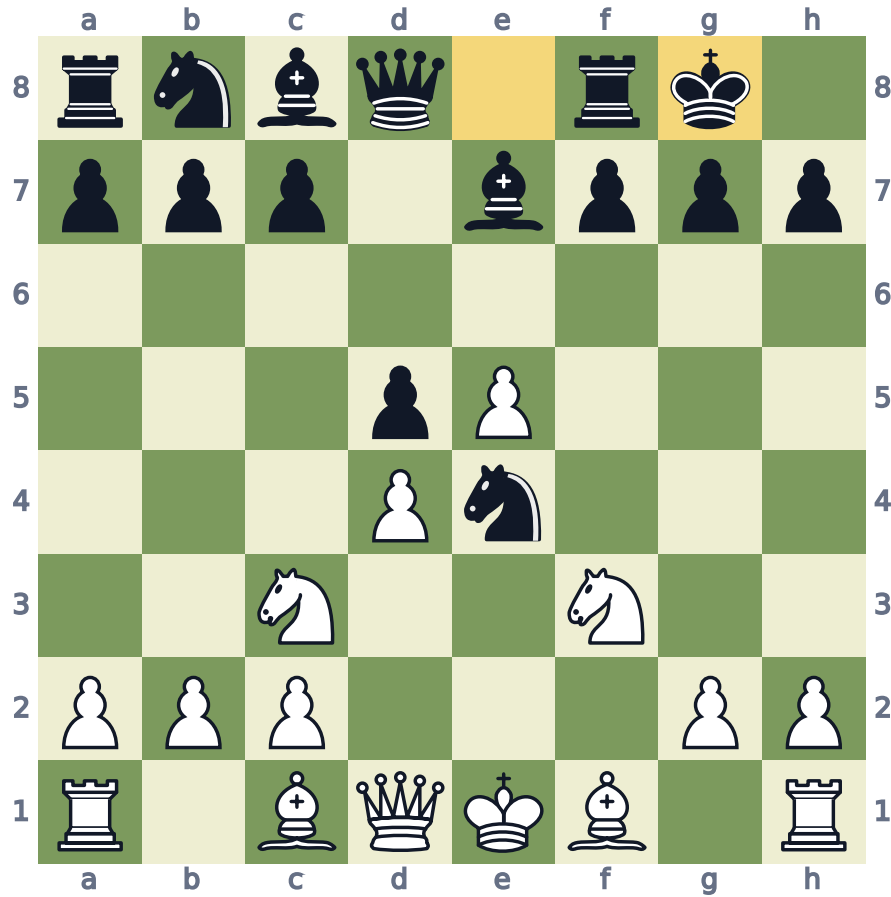
- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 23

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



4. fxe5 Nxe4 5. Nf3 Be7 6. d4 O-O

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Coordinate Before Accelerating'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A coordinated force can switch from attack to defense and exploit opened lines. Premature action creates targets faster than support can arrive. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring coordinate before accelerating. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

LEARNING UNIT 24

Compare Pieces by Future Potential

THE RULE

Evaluate not only current activity but also the ease and speed of improvement.

WHY IT WORKS

A passive piece with a clear route may be better than an active-looking piece that has reached its ceiling. Plans are races between improvement paths.

RECOGNITION CUES

The coordination determine the next plan, or a trade or pawn move will change their value.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Check tactics first.
- Evaluate material, kings, activity, structure, and space.
- Name the most important imbalance.
- Find the worst piece and the desired exchange.
- Compare plans by the counterplay they allow.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Piece rules are conditional. Verify tactics, move order, king safety, and the resulting pawn structure before applying the rule.

BOARD LABORATORY 24

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



4. h4 g4 5. Ne5 Nf6 6. Bc4 d5

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Compare Pieces by Future Potential'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A passive piece with a clear route may be better than an active-looking piece that has reached its ceiling. Plans are races between improvement paths. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Set up six positions featuring compare pieces by future potential. Name the ideal square, the route, the opponent's restriction, and the best exchange.

RETRIEVAL TEST

Can you explain the course without looking?

1

State the five-step decision protocol from memory.

2

Name three recognition cues that should make you slow down.

3

Choose five learning units and explain the causal mechanism behind each rule.

4

For each chosen rule, give one position where it should not be applied mechanically.

5

Describe the opponent's strongest practical resource in your most recent serious game.

6

Name one recurring error and the exact training drill that addresses its cause.

SCORING

2 points: accurate rule plus mechanism. 1 point: useful but incomplete. 0 points: slogan only. Restudy any item below 2 and retrieve it again tomorrow.

TRAINING PLAN

Four weeks to make the ideas usable

WEEK 1 - UNDERSTAND

Study the first quarter of the course. After every lesson, explain why the rule works and when it fails.

WEEK 2 - RECOGNIZE

Study the second quarter. Mix old and new diagrams so the name of the motif is not given in advance.

WEEK 3 - CALCULATE

Finish the course. Use a clock and write candidates, best defense, and endpoint evaluation.

WEEK 4 - TRANSFER

Play two slow games. Mark every moment when the course's protocol changed your decision, then analyze unaided.

LONG-TERM REVIEW

Return after 7, 14, and 30 days. Do not reread first. Attempt the retrieval test, review only missed items, and find one example from your own games.

REFERENCE

How this course fits the library

COURSE ROLE

Understand each unit as a problem-solving tool: what it needs from the pawn structure, what limits it, and how it coordinates with the rest of the army.

LIBRARY PRINCIPLE

Strong chess comes from a loop: notice the right features, generate serious candidates, calculate the opponent's best resistance, evaluate the destination position, and learn from the decision process.

ABOUT THE DIAGRAMS

Boards use Cburnett-style vector chess pieces with solid dark pieces and high-contrast olive and cream squares. Piece artwork is credited to Colin M. L. Burnett and the Lichess Cburnett set under GPLv2+.

EDITION NOTES

First edition, September 2026. 24 learning units. Explanations and exercises are designed for personal study and should be tested against actual games and concrete calculation.

THE FINAL QUESTION

What will you do differently on your very next move? If the course has not changed a behavior, choose one rule, attach it to a visible board cue, and practice it in five slow games.